

Final Project Checkpoint 2: Codebook and Data Description

DUE October 29 at 5 PM

Your second checkpoint will focus on understanding and documenting the dataset you selected in **Checkpoint 1**. You will create a codebook that clearly describes the variables you will use to test your hypothesis.

Since your dataset has already been provided based on your chosen research question, you do not need to search for or collect new data. Instead, you will:

1. Identify the variables in your dataset that measure:
 - Your **dependent variable** (DV), as defined in your research question.
 - Your **primary independent variable** (IV).
 - At least **two theoretically relevant control variables** that may also affect your DV. These should be variables you have identified from your literature review as important to include.
2. Make sure you are familiar with how these variables are coded and what their values represent.
3. Use the exact variable names from the dataset in your codebook so your documentation matches the provided data file.

Although you will not yet conduct your analysis, you should be able to:

- Locate the DV, IV, and control variables in your dataset.
- Understand how each variable is measured and coded.
- Begin thinking about whether any variables will need recoding or transformation for your analysis.

Your codebook should include for each variable:

- **Name:** The exact name of the variable in the dataset.
- **Level of measurement:** (interval, nominal, ordinal).
- **Source:** The article and dataset from which it comes (as provided in Checkpoint 1).
- **Coding:** How the variable is coded and what the values mean.
- **Notes:** Any additional clarifications (e.g., missing values, units, or recoding plans).

Here is an example of a codebook entry for an interval-level variable and a categorical variable (note you don't have to format your entries exactly this way, but codebooks often do take a tabular form):

Judicial Ideology (variable name)

My measure of judicial ideology is categorical and based on the party of the appointing president. This requires the assumption that presidents appoint justices who share their ideology.

Categorical

Values: 1 if appointed by a Republican president; 0 if appointed by a Democratic president; . = missing data.

Source: Epstein, Lee, Jeffrey A. Segal, Harold J. Spaeth, and Thomas G. Walker. 2012. *The Supreme Court Compendium: Data, Decisions, and Developments*. Washington DC: Congressional Quarterly.

Judicial Ideology (variable name)

My measure of judicial ideology is Martin and Quinn's Bayesian measure of judicial ideology based upon the votes of U.S. Supreme Court justices. Lower values indicate more liberal justices.

Interval

Values: Range from -8 to 4.5 with higher values indicating more conservative justices and lower values indicating more liberal justices; . = missing data.

Source: Andrew D. Martin and Kevin M. Quinn. 2002. "Dynamic Ideal Point Estimation via Markov Chain Monte Carlo for the U.S. Supreme Court, 1953-1999." *Political Analysis* 10: 134-153.

Please print your research question and hypothesis in bold at the top of your submission!

Grading Rubric (Total: 2 Points)

Completeness (1 point)

- **1 point:** if the assignment lists one dependent, one independent, and at least 2 control variables (with control variables being relevant).
- **0.5 points:** if the assignment lacks one of the above components.

Data Description (1 point)

- **1 point:** if the assignment includes the level of measurement, data source, and values for each variable.
- **0.5 points:** if the assignment lacks any of the above components or contains potentially incorrect information (e.g., a binary variable being identified as continuous).